ZikShare

ACADEMIC VAULT

UNIZIK FRESHER EDITION | 2026

GST 105: Humanities - Art, Literature, Music and the Examined Life

A guided tour of the humanities that gives you something real to say in the exam

GST / COMPULSORY

GST & Compulsory Courses

General Studies (GST / CED)
GST Directorate | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

Study smarter. Ask better questions. Pass with understanding.

Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

START HERE

Why this pack exists

Humanities questions look broad, so students answer with vague generalities. This pack gives you concrete definitions, examples and evaluation language for literature, visual art, music, theatre and philosophy, plus a method for analysing a work you have never seen before.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Define the humanities and explain why they matter beyond 'self-expression'.
- Analyse a poem, painting, piece of music or play using a repeatable framework.
- Explain the relationship between art, culture and society with Nigerian examples.
- Write a short evaluative answer that makes a claim, gives evidence and acknowledges complexity.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Why the humanities exist

The humanities study human experience and the meanings people make through language, image, sound, performance, belief and argument.

They are not soft subjects. They require close reading, historical context and judgment under uncertainty - the same skills you need to interpret a legal case, a patient's story or a business rumour.

The disciplines you will meet include literature, linguistics, history, philosophy, religious studies, music, theatre and film, and visual arts.

- Literature: how language creates meaning, character and value.
- History: how evidence is selected and interpreted to explain change.
- Philosophy: how concepts and arguments are tested.
- Music and theatre: how performance shapes emotion and community.

Analysing a poem without fear

Use the SOS method: Subject, Occasion, Speaker - then move to form and language.

1. Subject: what is the poem about in one sentence?
2. Occasion: what situation or moment triggered it?
3. Speaker: who is talking, and is it the poet?
4. Form: stanzas, line length, rhyme, rhythm, free verse.
5. Language: diction, imagery, metaphor, simile, personification, repetition.
6. Tone: the speaker's attitude, supported by specific words.
7. Theme: what the poem suggests about life, not just what happens.

> **Avoid the summary trap**
> Retelling the poem is not analysis. Every claim about meaning needs a quotation and a comment on the effect of the language.

Visual art and music as evidence

You do not need to be an artist to analyse art. You need to describe what is there before interpreting it.

- Visual art: subject matter, composition, colour, light, texture, scale, setting, and the artist's likely intention.
- Nigerian reference points: Nok terracotta, Benin bronzes, Igbo uli body painting, contemporary artists such as Ben Enwonwu and Njideka Akunyili Crosby.
- Music: instrument, rhythm, melody, tempo, dynamics, lyrics, call-and-response and context of performance.
- Theatre: script, performance, staging, costume, audience and director's choices.
- Always separate description from interpretation: 'The dominant colour is red' is description; 'The red suggests danger' is interpretation.

Writing an answer that earns marks

Humanities answers are judged on accuracy, evidence and reasoning, not on how emotional they sound.

1. Make a direct claim in the first sentence.
2. Define your key term immediately.
3. Give one concrete example - a text, artwork, event or practice.
4. Explain how the example supports the claim.
5. Add one qualification or counter-point.
6. Close with a sentence that answers the question, not with 'in conclusion'.

> **Useful sentence starters**
> This suggests that... / The choice of... implies... / A limitation of this reading is... / This matters because... Avoid 'it is a very interesting work' with no follow-up.